

MTPA. Operational efficiency improved dramatically, with container vessel turnaround times declining by 28% and berth productivity rising by 47%. Today, over 60% of cargo at major ports is handled through PPP, a figure targeted to reach 85% by 2030. This efficiency is reflected in global rankings, where the World Bank's Container Port Performance Index 2024 placed Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority at 23rd and Mundra at 25th among the world's top 30 container ports. Building on this success, India is now developing the ports of the future, such as the ₹76,000 crore Vadhvan Port in Maharashtra, which will handle 23 million TEUs, and the ₹48,000 crore International Container Transshipment Port at Great Nicobar Island, designed to capture regional transshipment traffic and save valuable foreign exchange.

The ₹70,000 Crore Blueprint: Forging a Global Shipbuilding Powerhouse

With the port infrastructure foundation firmly laid, India's maritime focus has shifted decisively toward the shipbuilding and shipping sectors under a comprehensive four-pillared policy package of ~₹70,000 crore. This transformation is essential to address a critical economic gap: currently, India ranks 16th globally in ship ownership, contributing less than 1% of global shipyard output. Furthermore, only 7% of Indian-owned ships are actually built in India, a disparity that forces the shipping services sector to drain approximately USD 75 billion annually in foreign exchange (FOREX) payments.

To realize a "Viksit Bharat" on the high seas, the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways has launched a coordinated approach under the National Shipbuilding Mission, which was announced by the Hon'ble Prime Minister on 20th September 2025 and launched by the Union Cabinet on 24th September 2025. This mission is anchored in an ambitious National Vision: Position India among the top 10 shipbuilding countries by 2030 and top 5 by 2047. The government's four-pillar strategy provides the financial and structural "teeth" to achieve these targets. This landmark reform includes the ₹24,736 crore Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Scheme (SBFAP), which neutralizes the 25-30% cost disadvantage faced by Indian yards and introduces "building from scrapping" via shipbuilding credit notes.

The second pillar is the ₹25,000 crore Maritime Development Fund (MDF), which provides low-cost, long-term financing to de-risk private capital. The third pillar, the Shipbuilding Development Scheme (SbDS), invests nearly ₹20,000 crore into greenfield shipbuilding clusters in Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, and Gujarat while supporting brownfield upgrades. Finally, the Demand Aggregation pillar provides unprecedented visibility with a vessel acquisition plan for over 437 vessels worth more than ₹2.2 lakh crore, including the newly formed Bharat Container Shipping Line (BCSL). This comprehensive package is expected to catalyze over ₹4.5 lakh crore in sectoral investments and create 30 lakh direct and indirect jobs, fundamentally shifting India from a maritime consumer to a global shipbuilding leader.



Landmark Orders and Bharat Container Shipping Line

Recent achievements underscore the success of these interventions, notably the strategic contract between CMA CGM and Cochin Shipyard Limited for six dual-fuel 1,700 TEU container vessels worth approximately ₹3,200 crore. This represents the first time a major global carrier has placed LNG dual-fuel container vessel orders in an Indian shipyard, with all vessels registered under the Indian flag. Other global majors like Hyundai, Samsung, and Damen Shipyards have also expressed keen interest or finalized collaborations for Indian shipbuilding clusters. These developments were showcased at the India Maritime Week (IMW) 2025, which saw the participation of over 1 lakh delegates from 93 countries and the launch of projects and MoUs worth a record ₹12 lakh crore. The BCSL itself is a key component of this growth, with a medium-term vision to build a 51-vessel fleet and a ₹59,840 crore capex plan to reduce India's heavy reliance on foreign shipping lines.

Masters of the Deep: The Seafarer Success Story

The human element of this transformation is equally compelling, as the number of Indian seafarers has reached 3.18 lakh, reflecting a significant increase in global share. Notably, there has been a ten-fold growth in the number of women seafarers since 2013-14, supported by digitalized certification systems like e-Samudra and e-Pariksha. Regulatory reforms, such as the Merchant Shipping Act 2025 and the Coastal Shipping Act 2025, have modernized the industry by replacing colonial-era laws with frameworks that promote freedom of flagging and seamless integration of coastal and inland waterways. These legislative changes are complemented by recent budget announcements, including a ₹10,000 crore Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme aimed at producing 1 million TEUs annually and bridging a 25-30% manufacturing cost gap compared to global competitors.

Viksit Bharat on the High Seas: A Future Written in Water

Sustainability and internal connectivity remain core to the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, with an investment potential of ₹75-80 lakh crore (approximately USD 885-940 billion). Inland waterways cargo has already grown by 700% over the last decade, and the government has committed to operationalizing 20 new National Waterways, including the ₹13,865 crore National Waterway 5 (NW-5) in Odisha. NW-5 will connect the mineral-rich hinterlands of Talcher and Angul to the ports of Paradip and Dhamra, significantly reducing logistics costs for bulk commodities. Concurrently, India is establishing Green Hydrogen Hubs at Deendayal, Paradip, and Tuticorin ports to lead the global transition to clean maritime energy. By 2047, India envisions an integrated maritime ecosystem with 10,000 MTPA port capacity, a top-five global ranking in shipbuilding, and 10 Indian ports in the global top 30.